

Common Versus Special

A warehouse story showing the real cost of treating normal noise as an emergency.

The Burned-Out Supervisor

At an e-commerce fulfillment center, a floor supervisor launched a full investigation every time an order beat its ten minute target by a little. He pulled workers off the floor, reviewed walking paths, and checked scanner logs, treating every minor delay as special cause. His team was exhausted and kept offering weak explanations because the same delays returned the next week.

Measuring The Baseline

The first question was how long picking takes on a normal day, and nobody knew, because they had never tracked a baseline. Two weeks of measurement showed an average of twelve minutes with a normal range of eight to sixteen. Anything inside that range was just common cause noise from the warehouse layout, with no single root cause to find.

Why It Matters

They set a simple rule. Between eight and sixteen minutes, do not investigate. Twenty minutes or more signals something special like a broken scanner or a spill. Within a month, investigation hours fell 60 percent and the remaining investigations were far more effective. With the Motorola lesson, this completes the bedrock of Six Sigma.

Remember this

Measure your baseline first, so you only investigate the signals that truly fall outside normal noise.